

In ראשון הוא it says (12:2): הַחֵדֶשׁ הַזֶּה לָכֶם רֹאשׁ חֳדָשִׁים, the first מצוה given to כלל ישראל as a nation: גמרא in גמרא in גמרא. The sefer שמחת התורה by R' Simcha Sheps offers a fascinating insight. He brings a גמרא in גמרא in גמרא - There were three topics that משה רבינו found particularly difficult; עד שהראה לו הקב"ה באצבעו - until משה explicitly showed each one with an אצבע, pointing and clarifying, "This is what I mean, this is what I want." What is the גמרא conveying here? Why did משה רבינו struggle specifically with these three?

First, תורה symbolizes תורה, as we know (משלי ו:כג) Moshe found it hard to grasp how the fundamentally divergent concepts of our עולם of גשמייות and the תורה, which is רוחניות, could connect. However, הקדוש ברוך הוא clarified that the world itself is sustained and only exists through the זכות of the עמוד התורה.

Next, שרצים, which are טמא, symbolize the אומות העולם. While כלל ישראל is called אדם (ע"ש יבמות ס"א ע"א), the אומות העולם are not. משה questioned how טהרה could influence טומאה, given the stark contrast between the holiness of כלל ישראל and the impurity of the אומות העולם. הקדוש ברוך הוא responded that the השפעה of the אומות העולם could indeed penetrate and affect the אומות העולם, a dynamic we occasionally see throughout history, but will only be fully realized in ימות המשיח.

Lastly, ראש חדש posed a similar conceptual challenge. משה wondered how the לבנה, emerging anew each month, could break through the darkness, which symbolizes גלות and הסתר פנים? How could we survive such profound darkness? Hashem reassured משה, explaining that even when the moon disappears into the night's blackness, it returns, breaking through the חשך. This renewal symbolizes קדושה shining through the darkness.

Each of these concepts shares a common theme: How can כלל ישראל survive and thrive in this עולם הזה? The answer is only because of the זכות of תורה. It's through this זכות - not through superior intellect, scientific achievements, or Nobel Prizes - that we maintain our special status. We have the זכות of תורה, and in that זכות we shall continue to succeed in עולם הזה with our עבודה of bringing אור to the גוים.

